

PRESIDENTIAL PARADE

Regional STARDOM

The next president of the party may not be an Advani favourite but a performer from the states



BALAPATE

BJP vice-president and an RSS point man. He is seen as the ideal low-profile person to lead the party without aiming for the prime minister's seat.



NARENDRA MODI

If the BJP scripts a return to hardline Hindutva, he is their star. But his ambitions for the top job will clash with that of the Delhi club and his presence may aggravate allies.



SHIVRAJ S. CHOUHAN

Adilgent worker, the Madhya Pradesh chief minister is a strong contender. Is seen more as a regional leader but considered capable of the central leadership.



KALRAJ MISHRA

Rajya Sabha member and former UP state president, he has RSS support. Vajpayee's confidant, he is adept at leading the BJP at this juncture.



NITIN GADKARI

Maharashtra BJP president, he is seen as a modern progressive face of the BJP. Has good equations with the RSS. But his electoral track record may let him down.

ONCE A PARTY THAT WAS PRETTY CERTAIN OF ITS ideological identity, the BJP today is a house of delusion. It is inhabited by leaders who are gifted with ambition but no ideas.

think that what Advani did then had strengthened his cause, his party and raised his esteem in the people's eyes." In his memoirs *My Country My Life*, he writes: "I continue to hold the view that I had expressed in the India Today interview... This debate (about Jinnah) is not about the past; it is about the future, in the light of the lessons from the past. For the issue that should be discussed is not so much Jinnah, but the future of Indo-Pak relations in the context of a new vision of peace, inter-religious harmony, and inter-state co-operation in all of South Asia." The conviction politician was very much on display. Jaswant took Advani's argument further and gave it a book-length legitimacy of scholarship and research. At the now-infamous session of introspection, when the ayatollahs in saffron asked for the heretic's head, Advani, the original deviant, felt no sense of solidarity with Jaswant; he did not bother to tell the neophytes in the party that BJP was not fragile enough to crumble under the weight of a book. He showed no conscience—or courage. When a wounded Jaswant

proved to be a bigger threat than his book, Advani just retreated, perhaps knowing that no words could have redeemed him. When Jaswant took him on over Kandahar and the cash-for-MPs scandal, Advani did not come out with his version of truth. Maybe he was silent because he hated to lie.

THE END OF AN AURA

The aura was anyway coming to an end. It began long ago. The halo of the Hindutva's long marcher was not there as he stared down from the cardboard legend of "Determined Leader, Decisive Government" in the last General Elections. It was his first and last battle for power, and at 82, he was determined to realise his ambition, and quite decisive about the style of his campaign—very presidential. In yet another desperate makeover, he sold himself as a moderniser—and a strongman for the hard times who was pitted against the "weakest" prime minister. Independent of the